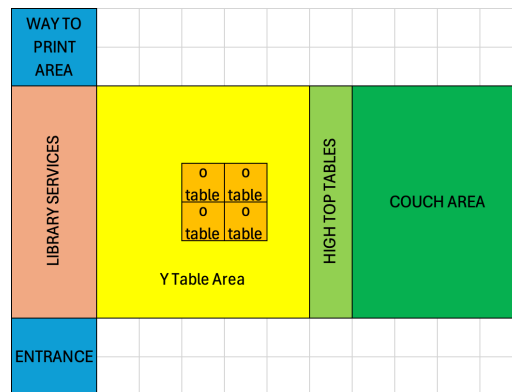


Ethnographic Journal #2



1. Fieldnotes (Chronological Observation)

Location: Mugar Library

Start of Observation: 03.20.2026 - 17:51

- 17:58: People are studying, most probably for their finals.
- 18:00: Someone is snacking while working. The snack is a one-pound bag of pretzel sticks.
- 18:07: There are writings on the whiteboards in the o table area. It seems like the writings have not been erased for a while.
- 18:10: There is a lot of collaboration between students, which create a lot of noise.
- 18:12: Students who are bothered by the noise use headphones.
- 18:19: Decibel Level is 29db.
- 18:19: Some students have some sort of media playing, either playing some music or show on the side.
- 18:25: Students go out and come back with food from the GSU food court.
- 18:27: The limited number of windows make it seem like nightfall has already come.
- 18:29: The use of fluorescent lights in this building have started to hurt my eyes.

18:33: The temperature is rather cool than warm. This may be because we are entering Spring and the school may have cut off heating.

18:39: The library is at 70% capacity.

18:44: This place feels a prison.

18:46: The group of students behind me are disturbingly loud, I'm turning on Active Noise Cancelling.

18:50: If a baby were here crying, nothing would matter, because it is very loud.

18:53: End of Entry

2. Ethnographic Interview

Interviewee Description:

I spoke to a BU student who appeared to be in their early 20s, sitting alone at a Y-shaped table a few spots away from me. They had a laptop open, headphones on (but one ear slightly off), and a notebook with handwritten notes beside them. They had been in the space for at least 30–40 minutes before I approached them, working continuously without leaving their seat.

Questions & Responses:

Q1: How do you decide to come to this specific area of the library instead of somewhere else?

Response: They said they usually choose this area when they “actually need to get work done.” They mentioned that other parts of the library feel either too quiet (like silent floors, which they described as “kind of stressful”) or too social, where they might run into friends. This area, according to them, is “in between”—there’s enough background presence of other people to stay focused, but not so much interaction that it becomes distracting. They also noted that seeing other people working makes them feel “guilty in a good way” if they start procrastinating.

Q2: What do you think people are expected to do or not do in this space?

Response: They paused for a moment and said, “I guess you’re supposed to look busy.” They clarified that people don’t necessarily have to be silent, but they shouldn’t be loud or draw attention to themselves. For example, talking is okay, but only in a low voice and usually briefly. They also mentioned that people are expected not to “spread out too much” or take up extra seats if it’s crowded. They described it as an “unwritten rule” where everyone is aware of others but doesn’t directly enforce anything.

Q3: Can you describe a time when someone ‘broke’ the usual behavior here?

Response: They recalled a time when a group of students sat nearby and started laughing loudly and talking as if they were in a dining hall. They said it stood out immediately because “everyone kind of looked up at the same time.” No one confronted the group directly, but the group eventually lowered their voices. The interviewee said that the reaction wasn’t aggressive, but more like a collective signal that they were being too loud. They described it as “you just know when you’re being too much here.”

Q4: How does being here affect how you work compared to working somewhere else?

Response: They said they are “definitely more focused” in this space compared to working at home or in a dorm. At home, they tend to get distracted by their phone or take breaks more often, but here they feel more committed to staying on task. They explained that just being around other people who are working makes them feel like they should also keep working. They also mentioned that they don’t check their phone as much because it feels more noticeable, even if no one is actually watching them closely.

Q5: What do you notice about other people here when you’re studying?

Response: They said they don’t actively observe others most of the time, but they still pick up on patterns. For example, they notice that most people are using laptops and wearing headphones, and that people tend to stay for long periods without moving much. They also mentioned that when someone does something unusual—like eating loudly, talking on the phone, or moving around a lot—it becomes very noticeable. They described the environment as “everyone doing their own thing, but still kind of aware of each other.”

3. Reflection (300 words)

For this observation, I interviewed a BU student who was sitting alone at a nearby Y-shaped table, working continuously on their laptop with headphones on. I chose this person because they had been in the space for a while without leaving, which made them seem familiar with the environment and its expectations. I approached them when they paused briefly and asked if they would be willing to answer a few questions. They agreed, and the interaction felt relatively natural, though I was still aware that I might be interrupting their workflow.

From the interview, I learned that this space is not just used for studying, but for maintaining a certain kind of discipline. Before speaking with them, I mostly experienced the environment as somewhat overwhelming and even uncomfortable, especially with the noise and lighting. However, they described the space as productive specifically because of the presence of others. What stood out to me was their idea that seeing other people working creates a kind of pressure to stay focused, which they described as “guilt in a good way.” This helped me understand that the space functions through subtle social influence rather than strict rules.

Their description of “looking busy” as an expectation also changed how I interpreted what I observed. What I initially experienced as random noise or distraction now seems more structured by unspoken norms. Even when people talk or eat, there is still a general awareness of not disrupting others too much. The example they gave of a loud group being silently corrected by others’ attention reinforced this idea.

Overall, the interview shifted my understanding of the space from chaotic to socially regulated. It made me realize that the environment is shaped not just by its physical design, but by how students collectively maintain certain expectations of behavior.